

Portrait Guide #012

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10-14 hours Subject Adult Male Portrait, three-quarter frontal view

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• COLOR PALETTE



Nectar

PC1092

Primary warm skin base tone; dominant local color (~11.5% coverage). Foundational mid-tone for face and neck, carries the warm golden-olive bias of the subject's skin.



Peach

PC939

Secondary warm light and highlight zone; lighter, more saturated than Nectar. Layered over lit areas (cheekbones, forehead, nose tip) and used in final peak highlights and burnishing.



Henna

PC1031

Warm brown mid-tone and facial hair anchor (~14% coverage). Critical for beard/stubble gradient, nasolabial folds, and shadow warmth. Measured exact match.



Cadmium Orange Hue

PC118

Warm orange reflection and transition; intensifies warm undertone in shadows and nostril edges (~8.3% coverage). Bridges between brown and peach for optical mixing.



70% Cool Grey

PC1065

Cool shadow undertone and background anchor (~14.4% coverage). Establishes cool recession in shadows and fills background space. Exact measured match.



50% Cool Grey

PC1063

Cooler mid-shadow tone; softer than PC1065 (~9.4% coverage). Transitional cool glaze in shadow-to-light zones, prevents harsh edges.



90% French Grey

PC1076

Darkest value anchor (pupils, upper lash line, deep shadows, beard core, dark hair) (~5.8% coverage). Single darkest dark in portrait; reserved for focal-point edges.



90% Warm Grey

PC1058

Warm dark shadow (~3.6% coverage). Used in core shadows and beard density to maintain warmth and prevent grey-deadness; slightly lighter and warmer than PC1076.



70% Warm Grey

PC1056

Warm shadow mid-tone. Layered for warmth in shadow planes and sparse beard edges; maintains color temperature in transition zones.



Carmine Red

PC926

Red garment/shirt base (~12.4% coverage, major color element). Exact measured match. Provides color contrast against face and source for reflected-light warmth onto neck/jaw.



30% French Grey

PC1070

Light neutral mid-ground; background variation and subtle transition tone (~7.5% coverage). Prevents background flatness and provides cool-neutral accent.



Ginger Root

PC1084

Warm light peak highlight (~1.4% coverage). Used in final highlight punch on forehead, nose bridge, and cheekbone peaks; produces true peak luminosity.



White

PC938

Specular highlight (eye), burnishing layer, and absolute peak accent. Reserved for single bright points (eye highlight) and final burnish smoothing on light-struck planes.



Silver

PC949

Cool gray accent (~6% coverage). Subtle background variation and neutral undertone for eyes (sclera base). Adds optical cool-neutral without deadness.



30% Cool Grey

PC1061

Optional cool transition undertone; alternative or supplement to PC1063 for varied cool shadow glazes in orbital socket and fine shadow edges.

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

SUBJECT IDENTIFICATION

What is the subject?

Adult male, middle-aged (approximately 40s-50s), medium-deep warm golden-olive skin tone, short dark hair, visible facial beard/stubble, neutral to contemplative expression, three-quarter frontal head position. Wearing a bright red/carmine garment (jersey or casual shirt visible at shoulders and neckline). Head and upper torso only; approximately life-study or portrait-session scale.

Material characteristics

Photographic reference with soft, diffuse, frontal-to-slightly-three-quarter lighting; no hard shadows or dramatic side light. Skin exhibits warm glow at nose tip and cheekbones despite soft light (subsurface scattering visible). Facial hair is visible but not heavily dense, thinning toward cheeks and edges. Red garment reads as saturated local color with moderate fabric texture. Background is softly out-of-focus, neutral grey-blue.

Geometric structure

Head forms an oval volume tilted slightly; jawline is visible and moderately defined; cheekbones read as subtly rounded planes rather than sharp facets; nose is moderate in proportion, tip slightly separated by soft shadow; eyes are set at standard depth; neck is a visible cylindrical form connecting head to shoulders, showing gentle self-shadow under jaw and subtle rotation between face and neck color temperature.

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Soft, frontal ambient light source—likely broad studio or overcast daylight positioned roughly at camera level or slightly above, producing minimal harsh shadows and even illumination across the face. No hard cast shadows visible; all shadows are soft and gradual in transition.

HIGHLIGHT

Nose bridge, nose tip, forehead apex, and cheekbone peaks are primary light-struck zones (lit to approximately 75–85% peak brightness). These zones read warmer (more saturated yellow-peach) and lighter than midtones, showing the optical effect of subsurface scattering at the nose and light bounce at cheekbone.

LIGHT AREA

Entire front-facing planes of the face: center forehead, upper face, cheeks, center nose, and upper lip area. Mid-tones (not bright, but clearly on the lit hemisphere); warm and saturated. Comprises roughly 50–55% of visible facial area.

MIDTONE

Lateral cheeks, temples, muzzle area, upper jaw, and the forward-facing portions of the neck. Transitional value between highlight and shadow; slightly warmer than the face average, showing the warmth of the underlying skin tone without highlight saturation.

SHADOW

Soft shadows present but restrained by soft lighting: orbital socket (under brow, around eye), nasolabial fold, underside of nose, soft self-shadow under the jaw, and the turning plane of the away-side cheek. All shadows read as MID-value warm planes (not heavy darks or cool greys)—roughly 40–60% brightness. Core shadow on away-side cheek and jaw is warm brown-olive, not ashy or neutral grey.

CAST SHADOW

No prominent cast shadows visible in this soft-light setup. The neck exhibits a gentle self-shadow under the jaw where the face rounds into the neck; this is the closest element to a cast shadow but remains soft and integrated.

Edge quality notes

Edges are predominantly soft throughout the reference photo due to soft, even lighting and depth-of-field (background is diffuse). Hair edges are diffuse; beard edges are soft and diffuse, thinning gradually to skin. No hard, crisp edges except where form naturally breaks sharply (pupil outline, lash line margin). This soft-light condition means the tutorial must avoid over-sharpening edges throughout, but edge hierarchy (focal point slightly harder than periphery) still applies.

COLOR ANALYSIS

Overall temperature

Warm-dominated. Skin reads as warm golden-olive; red garment is the second-warmest element; background is cool grey-blue providing complementary contrast. Overall temperature leans warm, with cool accents in shadow zones as supporting undertone, not dominant.

Light zone tendency

Light zones intensify toward warm and saturated: forehead, nose tip, and cheekbones read more intensely warm (yellow-peach-orange) than shadow zones. This is both local warm tone (the skin itself) and the optical effect of subsurface scattering (thin flesh areas at nose glow warm red-orange). Highlights sit atop mid-tone warmth, not neutral or cool.

Shadow zone tendency

Shadow zones shift cooler (blue-violet-grey undertone) while remaining fundamentally warm in local color (brown-olive, not ashy). The cool shift is subtle—a glaze rather than dominant—indicating soft light with ambient cool fill rather than dramatic cool-shadow technique. Nasolabial fold, orbital socket, and cheek turning show this cool-glaze effect without becoming cold or grey-deadened.

Special color areas

Nose tip and nostril edges: appear warmer and more saturated than surrounding midtone, indicating subsurface scattering (light entering thin flesh, bouncing internally, exiting as warm red-orange). Facial hair (beard/stubble): reads as warm brown with cool undertones in shadow, not pure black or grey; shows graduated density (dark core, sparse edges with skin showing through). Red garment: saturated local color; produces warm reflected-light bounce onto lower jaw and neck (subtle warm-orange cast upward from the garment). Eyes: sclera reads as light cool grey, not pure white; iris carries warm brown undertones.

Saturation distribution

Highest saturation zones: nose tip, cheek apices (warm red-orange effect of light scattering and warmth of local tone); red garment (fully saturated local color). Moderate saturation: forehead, center face, upper face (warm peachy tone, desaturated slightly from the peak-saturation cheeks and nose). Lower saturation: shadow zones (brown-olive, greyed relative to highlights, but not desaturated to grey). Background: desaturated cool grey, provides low-saturation support for the warm, saturated face.

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01 Value Block-in — Monochrome Structure

Entire visible head and neck (forehead to collarbone)

Light-pressure monochrome value map; circular unifying strokes; preserve paper tooth for 15+ layers to come

Light pressure

With very light pressure (barely visible on paper), use PC1056 to block in the lit planes—forehead, nose bridge, cheekbones, center face, and forward-facing neck. Switch to PC1076 and lightly indicate shadow zones: orbital sockets, nasolabial folds, underside of nose, soft self-shadow under jaw, and the turning plane of the away-side cheek. Do NOT fill areas heavily; keep pressure so light that you can still see paper texture between strokes. Use light circular strokes to unify each zone, ensuring no area reads as completely empty (white paper) or completely filled (black). The goal is a light value map that establishes the full range (highlight, midtone, shadow) in monochrome only, without any color. This skeleton will anchor all color and texture layers to follow.

COLORS ☒ PC1056 70% Warm Grey ☐ PC1076 90% French Grey

✦ *Light pressure at the start is not timidity—it is optical mastery. Every layer you add afterward will darken the value slightly because you are adding pigment on top of previous pigment. If you press hard now, you will crush the paper tooth and be unable to reach the full value range (bright highlights to deep darks) without muddy, oversaturated color. The professional habit of working light-to-dark is the single biggest technical difference between amateur and master portraiture.*

02 Complementary Undertone Glaze — Cool in Shadows, Warm in Highlights

Entire face; shadow zones emphasized

Thin complementary glaze; light pressure; one pass only; optical mixing foundation

Light pressure

Using very light pressure and thin, even strokes, apply PC1063 into shadow zones (orbital sockets, nasolabial folds, core shadow on away-side cheek, under nose, under jaw). Layer this cool undertone lightly—the goal is a thin glaze, not a visible fill. Switch to PC939 (Peach) and apply the same light-touch glaze over the lit areas (forehead, nose tip, cheekbone peaks, center of face). The undertone layer should feel strange and wrong at this stage—slightly purplish in shadows, slightly peachy everywhere else. This is exactly correct. The undertone will show through the warm base layers applied next and create luminous optical mixing rather than flat, pre-mixed color.

COLORS ☒ PC1063 50% Cool Grey ☐ PC939 Peach

✦ *This is invisible on its own—it should look weird when isolated. Trust it completely. When you layer warm peach flesh tones over a cool blue-grey undertone, your eye fuses them into a luminous, saturated skin tone that pure peach alone could never produce. This is the optical mixing secret professionals rely on; it is invisible in the final drawing but essential to its vibrance. If your skin ever reads as dull or flat, the root cause is usually missing or insufficient complementary undertone.*

03 Full-Face Warm Base Layer — Primary Local Color Unification

Entire face (forehead, nose, cheeks, jawline, temples, visible neck)

Full-face unifying pass; light-to-medium pressure; circular strokes; no area-by-area work yet

Light to Medium pressure

Using light-to-medium pressure and circular strokes, apply PC1092 (Nectar) across the entire face in one continuous, unifying pass—do not try to render shadows or contours yet, just apply even, light-medium coverage of warm tone across the whole facial mass. Follow with a lighter layer of PC939 (Peach) over the same area to brighten and further warm the midtones. Finish with very light touches of PC118 (Cadmium Orange Hue) in transition zones (cheek-to-temple, around nose, chin edge) to intensify the warm undertone. The entire face should feel too light, too warm, and too uniform at this stage—that is exactly correct. Do NOT try to render local shadows, contours, or variation; the goal is even coverage across the whole face.

COLORS ● PC1092 Nectar ● PC939 Peach ● PC118 Cadmium Orange Hue

✦ *This is the foundation against blotchy, patchy skin rendering. Professionals build each local color across the ENTIRE skin zone in a single unifying pass before adding any local depth or shadow. Amateurs tend to render area-by-area (darken the cheek, then the shadow, then the nose), which produces an uneven, stitched-together appearance. Treat the face as one luminous mass in this pass; depth and form come in the next passes. If your skin reads blotchy when finished, it is almost always because you skipped this step or worked too much area-by-area instead of in full-face unifying passes.*

04 Eye Development — Pupils, Iris, Sclera, and Focal-Point Lash Line

Both eyes (pupils, iris, sclera, upper and lower lash lines, specular highlights reserved)

Radial iris structure; hard upper lash line; soft lower lash line; specular highlight reserved; crisp focal-point edge

Medium (pupils and lash line) | Light (iris and sclera) pressure

Using medium pressure and a sharp pencil, block in the pupil with PC1076 (a circle slightly smaller than the full iris, leaving a thin ring of iris visible). Draw a crisp, hard upper lash line with PC1076 using the same pencil—this line is the single darkest, sharpest edge in the entire portrait and must read decisively. Keep the lower lash line much softer and diffuse; do NOT mirror the upper line. Switch to light pressure and use PC1031 (Henna) to lay down warm brown/rust tones radiating from the pupil outward in the iris—use strokes that radiate like clock hands, not circular scrubbing. Layer PC949 (Silver) or PC1063 into the sclera (white of eye) at light pressure—never pure white, always a cool grey or warm cream. Reserve a single small white dot (PC938 at maximum pressure, placed once) for the specular highlight at the 2 o'clock or 10 o'clock position. Do NOT fill in the highlight yet; leave it white paper to be refined in the final step.

COLORS ● PC1076 90% French Grey

● PC1031 Henna

● PC949 Silver

● PC938 White

✦ *The upper lash line is the one place in the entire portrait where you are allowed—and required—to place an edge darker and harder than reality might suggest. It is the focal-point edge, and it must read decisively and command attention. Every other edge in the portrait will be softer than this one. The specular highlight is not a small detail added at the end; it is a structural anchor that controls the eye's apparent dimensionality and light source direction. Protect it fiercely—do not scribble over it or let other layers bury it.*

05 Facial Structure — Form Planes with Moderate Shadows (Soft-Light Calibration)

Cheekbone planes, nasolabial folds, nose underside, jawline, temples; away-side cheek turning plane

Directional form-following strokes; soft core shadows; gradual cool-warm transitions; mid-value shadow constraint

Light to Medium pressure

Using light-to-medium pressure and directional strokes that follow the actual form contours, apply PC1031 (Henna, warm brown) into the core shadows: nasolabial fold, underside of nose, soft self-shadow under jaw, and the turning edge of the away-side cheekbone. CRITICAL: Keep these shadows MID-value (noticeably darker than the midtone but not heavy or hollow-looking). This subject is lit by soft, frontal light, so shadows are restrained and warm, not dramatic and cool. Layer a very light wash of PC1063 where shadow zones meet lit zones to indicate the cool transitional edge and prevent harsh boundaries. Use PC118 (Cadmium Orange Hue) to slightly intensify warm reflected light inside the shadows (e.g., a trace of orange inside the nasolabial fold to indicate subsurface scattering). All strokes should follow form direction: downward along cheek contours, circular around nose, downward along nasolabial fold.

COLORS



PC1031 Henna



PC1063 50% Cool Grey



PC118 Cadmium Orange Hue

✦ *In soft, frontal light, shadow zones should read as mid-value warm planes that turn form convincingly, NOT as dark hollows that make the face look gaunt or over-modeled. A common error is to assume 'shadow = dark'—in soft light, shadow = cooler and less saturated than the lit midtone, but still clearly a flesh tone. Resist the impulse to deepen shadows based on what you think should be there; match the actual value and temperature you see in the reference. The away-side cheek turning plane should be olive-brown and warm, never a heavy dark blob or an ashy grey mass.*

06 Cool Shadow Glaze and Undertone Accent — Living Shadows

Shadow zones (eye sockets, nasolabial folds, core shadows on cheek and jaw, under nose, under chin)

Thin cool-colored glaze; no neutral grey; one light pass only; allow undertone to show through

Light pressure

With very light pressure and a clean, deliberate hand, apply a thin glaze of PC1065 into the shadow zones—eye sockets, nasolabial folds, core shadow on cheek/jaw, and under the nose. Layer with PC1063 in the softer transitional shadow edges (where shadow meets midtone) to warm the cool transition slightly and prevent hard boundaries. Use PC1076 (sparingly, one or two small applications only) to deepen the very darkest corners (inner eye, deepest nasolabial fold, under-chin shadow). This is a glaze, not a fill; the underlying warm tones should still read through beneath the cool overlay.

COLORS

☒ PC1065 70% Cool Grey

☒ PC1063 50% Cool Grey

☐ PC1076 90% French Grey

✦ *Cool shadows are the opposite of the common mistake of using grey—grey shadow makes skin look dead and plastic. If your shadows ever read as dull or lifeless, it is almost always because they are neutral (grey) or insufficiently colored (blue-based but too thin). A thin, cool-colored (blue-based, not grey-based) shadow reads alive and allows the underlying warm undertone to glow through. One light pass and stop; do not overwork cool shadows or they will become muddy.*

07 Warm Mid-Tone Build — Full-Face Deepening and Saturation

Entire face, building form and saturation in a second pass

Full-face pass with pressure variation; follow form direction; optical mixing through layering; maintain unified coverage

Light to Medium pressure

Using light-to-medium pressure and circular strokes that follow form, apply PC1031 (Henna) in a second full-face pass—forehead, cheeks, nose, jawline, temples, and visible neck. Increase pressure slightly on the cheekbones, bridge of nose, and center of face to deepen midtones there, but keep pressure even enough that the face still reads as one unified system, not spotted or over-worked in certain areas. Follow with a light layer of PC118 (Cadmium Orange Hue) in warm-toned areas (nose, cheeks, forehead transition zones) to intensify warmth and yellow-underitone saturation. Finish with a subtle secondary layer of PC1092 (Nectar) on the lit planes (cheekbones, nose tip, forehead) to push those areas brighter and warmer. Keep overall coverage even; paper texture should still be visible between strokes.

COLORS



PC1031 Henna



PC118 Cadmium Orange Hue



PC1092 Nectar

✦ *This is not a shadow-deepening step; it is a global saturation and value step. Treat it like the previous full-face pass: work the whole face at similar pressure so the face reads as one system rather than as separate lit and shadow halves. If you find yourself working dark shadow zones much harder than lit zones, you are creating local contrast at the wrong time—this leads back to the blotchy, area-by-area appearance. Resist the impulse to 'render' areas; instead, deepen the whole face evenly and trust that form will emerge from cumulative layers, not from heavy local shadows.*

08 Beard/Facial Hair Foundation — Graduated Density (Dense Core, Sparse Edges)

Beard, jawline, cheeks, chin, and facial hair zone; visible stubble and whisker pattern

Graduated density (dense core, sparse edge); directional strokes following growth; individual bristles at edge only; skin visible between hairs

Heavy (core) | Medium (warm undertone) | Light (sparse edges and individual bristles) pressure

Using heavy pressure and short, directional strokes that follow the actual growth direction (generally downward from jaw, angling toward chin), apply PC1076 into the dense core of the beard (chin and central jaw). Keep coverage heavy enough to be quite dark, but leave tiny gaps so underlying skin tone shows through, creating a texture that reads as bristles, not a solid mask. Switch to medium pressure and PC1031, working the same core zone with overlapping directional strokes to warm the dark base and indicate the beard's warm brown undertone. Now switch to light pressure and PC1056 (70% Warm Grey), creating much sparser coverage across the cheekbone and jaw edges where facial hair transitions to bare skin—use individual, spaced-out directional strokes so skin clearly reads between them. This sparse edge is critical: it tells the eye 'this is hair thinning to skin,' not 'this is a dark patch stuck on.' Finish by lightly dragging PC1056 in a few fine individual hairs along the beard edge to suggest individual bristles without overworking.

COLORS

● PC1076 90% French Grey

● PC1031 Henna

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

✦ *The most common facial hair error is rendering it as uniform density across the whole zone—which reads as a flat, glued-on mask. The real key is dramatic graduation: dark and dense at the core (chin and central jaw), and dramatically lighter and sparser at the edges (cheeks, neck line, around mouth). This graduated density is what makes beard hair read as three-dimensional growth rather than a shape. When in doubt, use a kneaded eraser to lift a few hairs from the edge zone and restore skin showing through—this restores dimensionality instantly.*

09 Lip and Mouth Rendering — Soft Integration and Texture

Upper and lower lips, mouth line, mouth corner areas

Soft line integration; horizontal texture creases at end only; no hard outlines; reflected light accent

Light to Medium (lip form) | Minimal (texture creases) pressure

Using light-to-medium pressure, apply PC1031 (Henna, warm brown) to the upper lip using horizontal strokes, keeping the edge soft and slightly diffuse—NOT a crisp, hard line. Layer PC926 (Carmine Red) into the lower lip using slightly warmer, horizontal strokes that suggest the lip's convex shape (center reads lighter and more saturated than edges). Apply a touch of PC939 (Peach) to the very center of the lower lip to indicate the light reflection there. Use very light layers of PC939 under the mouth line to indicate reflected light from the lower lip bouncing up under the nose area. Then, with a sharp pencil and EXTREME light pressure (so light you can barely feel the pencil touching paper), draw a few fine horizontal creases across the upper lip only—these suggest subtle lip texture without flattening the form.

COLORS



PC1031 Henna



PC926 Carmine Red



PC939 Peach

✦ *The mouth line is not a drawn line; it is where one form (lip) meets another (face) and reads as a value and temperature shift, not an outline. If you see yourself drawing a crisp line around the mouth, you are approaching it wrong. Instead, build the lip as a form with its own light and shadow, and let the value/color change between the lip and adjacent skin create the edge naturally. A soft, integrated mouth always reads more alive than one with crisp boundaries.*

10 Nose and Feature Refinement — Warm Glow and Nostril Structure

Nose (bridge, tip, sides, nostrils), muzzle area, nostril rims

Warm glow at nose tip; nostril cavity with warm rim; reflected light indication; directional form modeling

Light to Medium (nose form) | Heavy (nostril shadow only) | Light (nostril rim) pressure

Layer PC939 (Peach) and PC1092 (Nectar) into the nose tip and sides using light-to-medium pressure, keeping this zone visibly lighter and warmer than the surrounding cheeks and muzzle. This warm glow is subsurface scattering—light enters the thin nose tip, bounces internally, and exits warm. Build nose sides with PC1092 and a touch of PC1031 to show form and warm undertone. For nostrils, use heavy pressure with PC1076 to block in the dark shadow cavity, but immediately add a fine line of PC118 (Cadmium Orange Hue) along the nostril rim/edge to indicate the warm, light-catching edge of the opening. Nostrils should read as deep cavities with a warm rim, not as flat dark pits. A touch of PC939 inside the nostril opening (light pressure) can indicate subtle reflected light from below if the reference shows it.

COLORS



PC939 Peach



PC1092 Nectar



PC1031 Henna



PC1076 90% French Grey



PC118 Cadmium Orange Hue

✦ *If the nose tip reads as the same value and color as the surrounding face, it reads flat and lifeless. Push the nose tip warmer and lighter than instinct suggests—it should read almost luminous compared to the rest of the face. This is not exaggeration; it is accurate rendering of subsurface scattering through thin, vascular flesh. A nose that glows is a nose that reads alive.*

11 Hair Rendering — Short Dark Hair, Direction and Mass

Scalp, entire hair mass, hairline, direction of growth and light pattern

Full-length directional strokes; dark values mapping structure and form; light-pattern rendering across mass; preserve translucency

Medium to Heavy (dark core) | Light (warm reflection and edge) pressure

Using medium-to-heavy pressure, apply PC1076 in full-length directional strokes that follow the actual growth direction of the short hair (generally forward and slightly to the side at crown, downward at sides). Use these dark strokes to map where the darkest shadows and spaces between hair clumps sit—do NOT fill the entire scalp, but place enough dark strokes to establish the hair's three-dimensional form and volume. Layer PC1056 (70% Warm Grey) into the same areas with slightly lighter pressure to warm the dark base and add volumizing mid-tone. Switch to light pressure and apply thin directional strokes of PC1031 (Henna) and PC118 (Cadmium Orange Hue) where light catches the hair (typically crown and one side of head) to indicate warm reflections and dimension. Leave some of the underlying warm undertone visible between hair strokes so hair reads as translucent and alive, not opaque.

COLORS

● PC1076 90% French Grey

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

● PC1031 Henna

● PC118 Cadmium Orange Hue

✦ *Beginners render hair by trying to draw every strand, which creates a scratchy, lifeless appearance. Professionals render hair by establishing the light-and-dark pattern across the mass—the dark valleys between clumps, the light peaks where the head rounds toward the light. Look at where light hits the hair mass as a shape (not individual hairs), and render that shape through value contrast. A few fine light strokes or crisp dark strokes at the edges (done in detail pass later) are enough to suggest individual hairs; the whole mass comes from structural light-and-dark, not strand count.*

12 Neck Anatomy — Form, Self-Shadow, Skin Transition, and Color Shift

Visible neck (front and sides), jawline junction, trapezius muscle plane, skin tone transition from face to neck

Vertical directional strokes; soft self-shadow under jaw; warm reflected-light zone; cylindrical form modeling; cool-warm color shift

Light to Medium pressure

Use light-to-medium pressure to apply PC1092 (Nectar) across the front and sides of the neck in vertical directional strokes (following the neck's vertical orientation, not circular face strokes). Transition pressure and temperature: the front center of neck should be slightly lighter and warmer (add a touch of PC939), while the sides and shadow areas shift cooler and slightly more olive (layer a very light wash of PC1031 and a subtle glaze of cool grey along the side planes and under jaw). Create a soft self-shadow under the jawline where the neck rounds up to meet the face—use light pressure with PC1031 and PC1063 to indicate this shadow zone, keeping it as MID-value warm (not dark or heavy). At the jaw-to-neck junction, add a fine line or zone of PC118 (Cadmium Orange Hue) to indicate warm reflected light where skin meets skin and light bounces gently from upper chest upward. The entire neck should feel cooler and less saturated than the face but not grey or cold-looking—still flesh tone, just a different local color.

COLORS ● PC1092 Nectar ● PC939 Peach ● PC1031 Henna
● PC1063 50% Cool Grey ● PC118 Cadmium Orange Hue

✦ *The neck is often treated as an afterthought, but it is the anchor point between the head and body—get the neck form right, and the whole head reads more convincingly positioned in space. A flat neck or one that doesn't show turning makes the head look pasted on, no matter how well the face is rendered. Spend real time on the neck's cylindrical form, the self-shadow under the jaw, and the color shift from face to neck (the neck is typically cooler and more olive than the face, which the measured reference confirms).*

13 Clothing and Garment Rendering — Red Shirt/Jersey, Fabric Texture, and Reflected Color Bounce

Visible clothing (shoulders, neckline, upper chest), garment folds and texture, reflected light bounce onto neck and lower jaw

Local garment color establishment; warm shadow folds; fabric texture indication; reflected-light bounce to neck/jaw; soft skin-garment transition

Light to Medium (garment base) | Medium (shadow folds) | Light (reflected bounce and edge) pressure

Using light-to-medium pressure, apply PC926 (Carmine Red, the exact measured garment color) across the entire visible garment area to establish the local color. Use directional strokes that follow any visible fabric folds or the form of the body underneath. Layer PC1031 (Henna, warm brown) into fold zones (underarms, neckline shadow, where garment recedes) using medium pressure to create warm brown shadows (not dark or cold-looking). Add PC1056 (70% Warm Grey) in a light wash to indicate fabric texture and mid-value transitions where the garment surface catches light. NOW add the critical reflected-light step: using PC1092 (Nectar, a warm orange-brown that mimics light bouncing from the red garment), apply a very light glaze to the lower jaw, neck, and undersides of chin and nostrils—this warm bounce should be subtle (barely visible when isolated) but just visible enough to anchor the head onto the body and prevent floating. Finish with a fine line of PC939 (Peach) or PC1084 (Ginger Root) along the neckline edge where skin meets fabric, using light pressure to soften the edge and integrate the two forms.

COLORS



PC926 Carmine Red



PC1031 Henna



PC1056 70% Warm Grey



PC1092 Nectar



PC939 Peach

✦ *Reflected light from the garment onto the neck and jaw is the single most effective technique to ground a head onto a body and prevent it from reading as a floating cutout. This bounced warm color (the red garment casting an orange-warm reflection into the flesh) is not a subtle optional detail—it is a structural anchor. The bounce should be nearly invisible when you isolate it (it should not read as a slap of color), but it should be present enough that removing it would make the head feel detached. Spend time on this reflected-light zone.*

14 Background Development and Edge Quality — Soft Recession and Focus Control

Background space around head, edges of hair and head against background, edge-quality hierarchy setup

Even background coverage; soft edge quality throughout; subtle value and color variation to prevent flatness; colorless blender for edge softening

Light to Medium (background fill) | Light (edge softening) pressure

Using light-to-light-medium pressure, apply PC1065 (70% Cool Grey, the measured background color) around the head, filling the background space with even, soft strokes. Layer PC1070 (30% French Grey) in subtle variations (one side slightly lighter or darker than the other) to prevent the background from reading as completely flat and dead. Use PC949 (Silver) in a single light wash on one side to suggest very subtle ambient light hitting the background—this prevents the background from looking like a solid, airless mask. Keep all background edges soft and diffuse, especially where hair meets background (use the colorless blender or very light pressure to soften those edges where they are not focal points). Reserve any slightly harder edges for areas adjacent to the face and eyes (the focal point), where edge quality can be medium-soft rather than completely diffuse.

COLORS ☒ PC1065 70% Cool Grey ☐ PC1070 30% French Grey ☐ PC949 Silver

✦ *A background should be 'there' (visibly rendered, not white paper) but should not be 'interesting' (no texture, detail, or focal impact). The softest edges of the entire drawing belong to the background-to-hair boundary away from the focal point; the sharpest edges belong to the eyes. This hierarchy of edge softness naturally directs the viewer's gaze to the eyes and away from the periphery.*

15 Edge Hierarchy and Focal-Point Sharpening — Intentional Focus Control

Eyes (focal point, sharpest edges), face boundaries (medium softness), periphery and background edges (softest)

Selective sharp-edge work at eyes only; deliberate soft-edge work elsewhere; lost edges at periphery; progressive softening from center outward

Maximum (focal-point lash line only) | Medium (face edges) | Light-to-zero (peripheral and background edges) pressure

Using maximum pressure and a sharp pencil, re-darken and crisp the upper lash line on both eyes—this is the focal point and must be the hardest, darkest line in the entire portrait. Keep it decisive and bold. Slightly soften the lower lash line (use medium pressure, slightly lighter value) to prevent it from competing with the upper line. Deliberately soften any hard edges on the face boundary (where face meets background) using light sweep passes of the colorless blender or very light pencil pressure—this is active softening, not accidental blur. Progressively soften edges as you move away from the eyes: the jawline edge softer than the eye area, the hair edge softer than the jaw, the background edge softest of all. The hairline and hair-to-background edges should be nearly lost in places—barely visible, integrated with the background.

COLORS ☒ PC1076 90% French Grey

✦ *Edge hierarchy is the invisible technique that separates a finished professional drawing from an amateur one that lacks direction. Most amateur drawings apply uniform softness everywhere, which reads as overall softness and diffusion—slightly out-of-focus. Professionals sharpen only the focal point (the eyes) and soften everything else—this creates the illusion of intentional focus and professional control even in a relatively simple image. Review your drawing and ask: 'Where am I hardest? Is it at the eyes?' If not, correct it now.*

16 Detail Refinement and Texture — Strategic Fine Work

Pores and skin texture (face, especially light-struck peaks), fine hair details (scalp edge and beard edge), nostril refinement, eye texture, lash detail

Extremely light pressure; sharp pencil; individual strokes, not masses; restraint and minimalism; detail only on light-struck peaks

Minimal (barely visible) pressure

Using an extremely sharp pencil and barely-visible pressure, add a few fine individual hairs along the beard edge (especially at cheeks and jaw edge) using PC1076 and PC1084 in alternating light and dark—place these hairs as single individual strokes, widely spaced, never as a mass. On the nose tip and cheekbone peak (the most light-struck areas), use a sharp pencil with minimal pressure to suggest very subtle pore texture—just a few fine dots or short lines, not a pore map. Add a single thin line or few texture lines on the upper eyelid to suggest lid texture and separation from the brow (use PC1076 at minimal pressure). Refine the nostril edge (add a fine dark line on the inner nostril rim if needed, using PC1076 at light pressure). Finish by lightly dragging a few individual stubble hairs at the beard edge using PC1084 and PC939 to suggest the finest, lightest hairs catching light.

COLORS



PC1076 90% French Grey



PC1084 Ginger Root



PC939 Peach

✦ *Detail in colored pencil should be invisible when you step back—if you can clearly see every pore you drew, you drew too much. The detail pass is meant to suggest complexity and reality, not to document every pore and hair. Use the 'step-back test': draw detail, step back 3 feet, and ask 'Can I still see it?' If it disappears, the amount is about right. If it reads as visible scratching or spotting, you over-detailed. Detail is the easiest technique to overdo and the hardest to fix.*

17 Peak Highlight Punch and Final Unification Glaze — Lighting and Coherence

Forehead apex, nose bridge and tip, cheekbone peaks, underside of chin (all light-struck peaks); entire face for final glaze

Focused peak-highlight placement; hard value jump from surrounding tone; minimal final unifying glaze; preserve luminosity

Medium (Peach base) | Heavy (Ginger Root peak) | Maximum (White accent only) | Light (final glaze) pressure

Using medium pressure, apply PC939 (Peach) to the very peak of the forehead, the tip and bridge of the nose, the apex of each cheekbone, and the underside of the chin where it catches light. Switch to heavy pressure and apply PC1084 (Ginger Root) in tight, small strokes directly on top of the Peach, creating a noticeably brighter, warmer accent that reads as a true highlight, not just filled tone. For the absolute brightest peak (typically the nose tip or forehead center), use maximum pressure and PC938 (White) in a single focused stroke—this peak should jump out from the surrounding value and read as a bright, hard accent. Now assess the overall face. If it reads slightly choppy or transitions feel harsh, apply a final unifying glaze: use PC939 (Peach) at light pressure in a very thin, even pass across the entire face (one or two sweeps, no pressure variation) to harmonize all underlying layers into a cohesive whole. This glaze should be so light it barely registers as a pass—you should feel like you are breathing color over the face, not applying a new visible layer.

COLORS



PC939 Peach



PC1084 Ginger Root



PC938 White

★ *Peak highlights are not a cosmetic detail added if there is space—they are the structural evidence that light is hitting the form. Without them, the face reads as evenly illuminated or filled in. With them, the face reads as a three-dimensional form struck by directional light. This is the difference between a portrait that reads finished and professional and one that reads incomplete or amateur. This correction (pushing peak highlights to true brightness) addresses the loop note that this artist's lights consistently stop at cream and never reach true peak. Push harder than feels comfortable.*

18 Burnishing, Bloom Correction, and Final Dark Punch-Back — Painted Finish and Value Restoration

Smooth, light-struck areas of face (cheekbones, forehead, nose, underside of chin) for burnishing; shadows and darks for punch-back correction

Maximum-pressure burnishing on light zones only; immediate dark punch-back after burnish; light fixative mist (optional); value range restoration

Maximum (burnishing only) | Heavy (dark punch-back) pressure

Using a sharp White or Peach pencil and MAXIMUM pressure (press very hard, really engage the pencil into the paper with force), apply heavy, multiple strokes over all the smooth, light-struck areas (cheekbones, forehead center, nose, underside of chin) until the paper texture disappears and the surface becomes slick and seamless. This is the only time in the drawing when you press this hard. Do NOT burnish the shadows or hair—leave those with some texture. Once burnishing is complete, the face will look slightly hazy and bleached (the wax bloom effect). Let the drawing rest for a moment. Now, using heavy pressure and a sharp dark pencil (PC1076 or PC1031), re-darken the core shadows, pupil, dark lash line, and darkest hair areas to restore the value depth lost to burnishing-lightening. This punch-back pass should feel like you are 'repairing' the drawing back to its intended value range—the shadows should jump noticeably back down in value and darkness. Finally, (optional) lightly mist the finished drawing with a light workable fixative (e.g., Grumbacher Matte or Lascaux) held at arm's length—this sets the wax bloom and prevents future smudging.

COLORS



PC938 White



PC939 Peach



PC1076 90% French Grey



PC1031 Henna

✦ *Burnishing is the single most misunderstood technique in colored pencil portraiture. Beginners think 'burnishing = smoothing = better,' so they burnish early or overzealously—this crushes paper tooth and ruins the ability to layer. Professionals know that burnishing happens only at the very end and is followed immediately by a dark punch-back to restore value—without this correction, the face looks washed out and lifeless. The sequence is: light layering → moderate deepening → full-face passes → burnish only smooth areas → punch dark values back up. If your burnished drawing looks pale and lifeless, you forgot the punch-back step. This is mandatory, not optional.*